For I Passed Through the Darkness (and I came out singing)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29525658.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Shadow Weaver PoV, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Child Abuse, To Train Up a Child referenced, abuser perspective, Adora and others are featured but are not the primary focus, catradora endgame but not primary focus, Abuse, Physical Abuse, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Shadow Weaver thinks she's the hero of this story but she isn't, Angst with a Happy Ending, Whump, Heavy Angst, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Final Chapter is Catra's PoV, Additional Tags to Be Added if Requested, Dead Dove: Do Not Eat

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by Nny11

Summary

Beatrix glared down into the crib where her daughter slept. Not a child. Not a human. Not her baby, no, no, no. Her punishment. This was her punishment and Beatrix refused to accept it. She had done her best, she had only ever wanted to do her very best. This animal she had birthed would be trained. Would be taught. It would learn. And she would scream with her defiance as she took it and shaped it into a proper human.

Notes

Keep in mind as your read this that Shadow Weaver is a VERY unreliable narrator who thinks she's the good guy doing the right thing. She's not, she's really, really not so take everything she thinks with a grain of salt.

I also need to say up front that I did not experience child abuse growing up, but that I did have a sensitivity reader (who would prefer to remain unnamed) give this a look over as well.

Inside this chamber, I carry my bane

Chapter Summary

> Birth was a truly horrible, nasty experience. And motherhood, a sacred thing, was not meant to be a lie and a trick. She had done nothing to deserve such cruelty.

Chapter Notes

> PLEASE read the tags and check the warnings. This fic is from Shadow Weaver's perspective and based heavily around To Train Up A Child, which is a horrific child abuse manual. So if the topic of child abuse is triggering for you or even just a squick this is not the fic for you, please be safe and kind to yourself!
>
> A big thank you to Venn364 and Jeitoless for editing/beta reading this fic!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Birth was a horrible, nasty experience. No matter what anyone else said, she'd known that as a fact. Birth was dangerous, bloody, and rarely as gentle as one might think. It was a crucible to be tested within.

Beatrix could remember glaring at the small bundle in her arms. Alone at home (at last) but for her sleeping "infant child", the feeling of burning resentment, and the agonizing ache in her chest as she tried and failed to find joy in this moment.

Motherhood was a *gift* after all. A gift for those found worthy and thus a goal...a desire. A symbol of success and womanhood. A cause for respect and celebration!

It was ashes in her mouth. It was the rage that never quite died in her veins. It was everything that had gone wrong in her life

bundled so lovingly by faceless nurses, now tucked into the crook of her arm to be admired.

That night- that first night home from the hospital, Beatrix had known that all she'd been told was lies and *lies* and **lies**. The disgusting creature in her arms was a hellish curse.

Oh yes. She'd known her daughter for the demon she was from birth.

Nearly twenty hours of labor that came prematurely. Perinatal asphyxiation. Third degree episiotomy tear. She'd watched the nurses and orderlies clean up the bloody sheets as her baby finally began to wail, crying and screaming and carrying on. Yowling like an animal, like a beast, while she had remained strong without the interference of poisoning drugs. A cry was important, yes, but it did not settle or calm even when placed still covered in horrible fluids on her chest. Beatrix had hated *it* from that very moment.

"What a beautiful girl!" They had cried and cooed, acting like children admiring a particularly marvelous bauble.

Beatrix had smiled, making sure her eyes crinkled even through her exhaustion. "Yes," she agreed, "my baby...my beautiful baby."

A baby. Ha! Idiots! Fools with scales on their eyes! A *baby*. The creature gave her no rest, gave no quarter, took no less than everything in her and no true babe would be so cruel.

She held that despicable bundle, hissing as it refused to latch and suckle. The humiliation of bottle feeding and formula while she still had to pump viable milk cut to the bone. Worse yet, it threw up and she found blood in its diaper. Lactose intolerant, born that way the doctor said. Beatrix had listened to it howling as she poured her own milk down the bathroom sink and wondered, what good was a baby that could not feed naturally?

Then there had been the rash that broke out because of the diapers used, forcing her to switch to a disposable brand,

probably plastic and chemicals...it stabbed at her heart. As if she had not debased herself to wash shit and piss off of the softest microfiber squares with only the best detergents and softeners. As if she had not tried to give it the **very best** option. Whimpering and crying as soon as it soiled itself, as if a few hours was some lofty sacrifice or torture, then twisting and worming to get away when changed.

The pacifier refused, the teething rings ignored, and yet it always found a way to gnaw at her hands. Dribbling drool and snot on her nice clothes, vomiting when burped even with the despicable formula. And tears. Always tears and always CRYING!

No.

Birth was a truly horrible, nasty experience. And motherhood, a sacred thing, was not meant to be a lie and a trick. She had done nothing to deserve such cruelty.

No.

Beatrix glared down into the crib where her daughter slept. Not a child. Not a human. Not her baby, no, no, no. Her *punishment* . This was her punishment and Beatrix refused to accept it. She had done her best, she had only ever wanted to do her very best. This animal she had birthed would be trained. Would be taught. It would *learn* . And she would scream with her defiance as she took it and shaped it into a *proper human.*

Or she would weep with defeat as she killed it.

It.

Her daughter.

The demon.

C’yra.

Chapter End Notes

So this whole fic is actually written, edited, and got a sensitivity check. As such there will be an actual posting schedule once a week on Saturdays!

Suspicion is like a wild starving dog, that when left alone will feast on itself

Chapter Summary

> “And now you are crying, tell me are you hurt? Are you bleeding? Do you need a doctor?”
>
> “No mama."
>
> Beatrix placed the ruler gently on C’yra’s arm, resting it there without hitting as a reminder while she said, “Then you have no need to cry. Walk it off.”

C’yra was testing her again, Beatrix could feel it in her soul.

Now nearly three years old it had, somehow, grown more defiant. The crying had never stopped, it refused potty training, and often refused to use words. Choosing to snivel and howl instead, chanting a pathetic litany of “mama, mama, mama” as if Beatrix could simply read its mind.

She had learned, when she was young and her own mother had given her responsibilities, that animals respond not just to what you say, but how you say it. Yelling and screaming would get you nowhere, for they would respond to the volume and the tone and not the order. With training though, any creature could be taught to respond to a calmly stated phrase. If a dog could learn, so too would this child.

“No, that is not for you.” Beatrix spoke soft and even, reinforcing her original verbal command through repetition. In one hand she loosely held a thin wood ruler. And she watched and she waited.

C’yra cradled its left hand, tears already pooling as it sniffled. A clear ploy to manipulate her into capitulating. It stared forlornly at the small plush cat and groaned, stomping little feet up and down as it blinked furiously.

She would give the creature every chance within reason, after all, it was thick and slow. So, she reminded. “Use your words.”

C’yra whined, clutching its hand tighter as if the two small taps of the ruler had broken bone instead of barely leaving a pink mark which had faded within seconds. It furiously shook its head before managing to speak, “Mine Whiskers! I want- I want Whiskers!”

“Is it playtime?” She asked, one brow arched at the head shake she received. One quick but gentle switch with the ruler to its back preceded her second reminder, “Use your words. I will not tell you again. Is it playtime?”

C’yra arched as if mortally wounded, theatrically throwing her head this way and that. “No. Wah-want Whiskers please!”

Despite the headache brewing and the rage flashing through her veins at her child’s insolence, Beatrix kept her voice even and calm. “No, it is not playtime, as you just said. You must clean up C’yra. It is time to clean up.”

C’yra rubbed the tears from her eyes before returning back to pick up her toys. Feet dragging as she went to place them back in her toy chest. Two taps and three reminders. It was a new record. A glimpse of the good little girl that could be.

When littler still, Beatrix had found that a quick sharp tug to her daughter’s hair and a firm but softly spoken no was enough to teach it not to bite. It took a few days, yes, but it worked. She’d realized then, feeling foolish all the while, her daughter wasn’t human yet and required more training than a true baby would. C’yra was still young yet and punishing it for bad behavior was ineffective. Training was key.

Consistent training.

She’d started with ignoring the cries meant to twist her emotions in on themselves. C’yra had been taught to respond promptly when called for when barely a year old. Then it had been training to not grab Beatrix’s food or touch her things. It took longer

before C'yra had stopped trying to root through her purse like some street vagrant, but learned she had. Teaching and training. Molding through methods it could comprehend. Not that it often stuck.

C'yra was the most willful child she had ever met. So repetition was, unfortunately, required.

And this particular toy was always a good one to use.

C'yra's ridiculous attachment to it allowed for additional training as needed, and *it* always needed some training at home. Public displays of disobedience had been dealt with both outside and at home, always with an explanation as to why she was going to do what she was. And out there, luckily, with the prying, judging eyes of the world upon them, C'yra had learned. Beatrix wouldn't lie and say she didn't feel some pride and satisfaction as she watched her daughter wipe her eyes dry instead of screaming away. She also knew that it simply wouldn't last. In public her daughter could become calm and stoic, yet at home her defiance continued.

So *she* continued. Her child would learn to obey her authority, to be a good child, a good girl. But until then, Beatrix would show the same leniency to it as it showed to her.

C'yra returned, moaning through clenched teeth, eyes sparkling once more with tears. A quick survey of the room found one toy still left out, half hidden behind the bookshelf. Beatrix pointed to it, frustrated to have needed to assist. As if the simple act of picking up *toys* was some grand labor.

"No. You are not finished cleaning up." When it growled, Beatrix's temper flared. She grabbed one chubby arm and firmly moved it to stand between her and the coffee table, well within sight of the stupid toy. If C'yra wished to be obstinate, then this required a firmer hand. Oh, it tried to squirm away, muted groaning becoming hiccupping sobs. "You did not clean up. You did not

speak using your words. Do not fight me child, this behavior is intolerable!”

She still waited until it growled or cried or tried to move, timing was key. Quick light smacks with the ruler were used only when required, only when her orders had been disobeyed. It would take time for the little creature to wear itself out, and Beatrix waited patiently as she could. Her frustration would not win. Her anger would not win. She would not allow a toddler to dictate anything to her, especially not this one. Beatrix corrected, repositioned, and waited. Eventually, as it always did, her daughter ceased her struggles. Standing perfectly still and not even looking at the beloved toy.

She waited a few minutes more before speaking, “It is time to clean up C’yra, do you understand?”

“Yes mama.” C’yra’s voice hitched, full of emotion.

“What did you do wrong?”

“No cleaned up. Mmmm- n-no speak up. Wanted Wh-Whiskers.”

“And now you are crying, tell me are you hurt? Are you bleeding? Do you need a doctor?”

“No mama,” the miserable little wretch sobbed. The little girl vanished once more; the beast remained.

Beatrix placed the ruler gently on C’yra’s arm, resting it there without hitting as a reminder while she said, “Then you have no need to cry. Walk it **off** .”

Still crying, but at least making an effort to now be quiet C’yra tugged until the last toy finally came free and then dutifully put it away. It returned and didn’t ask for the cherished cat, didn’t even look at it. If the little brat had followed directions, Whiskers would have been happily given over. Beatrix would not reward such appalling behavior as she’d seen by allowing it to play with the

toys she lent it. Instead she stood, ignoring the small stuffed cat as well. “It is time for your bath.”

As she watched C’yra slowly go to the stairs to strip and put her clothes away, Beatrix placed the ruler down. Good behavior was never its own reward, and on the heels of such an episode she knew that this was merely another ploy to act as if it was a good child before asking for the cat again.

Always testing and scheming, Beatrix was not surprised when the request came. A swift and decisive no ended the conversation, and C’yra did not ask again.

She still watched suspiciously half the night outside of her daughter’s room and was pleasantly surprised to not hear crying nor find her trying to sneak out. She was so *close* . So *very* close!

Patience, she reminded herself, patience was a virtue. Patience would win her this war of wills.

It starts with highs, and ends with lows (I think that's how the canary song goes)

Chapter Summary

> And if nothing else...perhaps she too could spend more time with this golden child. A good girl, a proper good girl like she had deserved. As pathetic as pretending would be, Beatrix was tired. And sweet, little Adora could prove to be her saving grace.
>
> "Yes...they do seem rather taken with one another, don't they?" Beatrix smiled. "Perhaps this is the start of a beautiful friendship."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Beatrix watched as C'yra hauled herself across the monkey bars, swinging from one to the next with a strength and grace that the other children at the park were severely lacking. She made sure to hide her smirk, more to prevent C'yra from misunderstanding and taking her approval as praise than out of a desire to hide it from others.

Her daughter had changed as the years had gone by, going skinny and lanky as she grew into her own skin. The wiry strength she had seen only growing once she'd gotten older, saner, and become human at last. It was a bitter victory, one that stung at her heart and throat if she let herself think on it too long. Yes, her daughter had been molded into a proper human child, but not a *good* child.

The distinction grated.

And that frustration led to dread. Beatrix knew that after almost seven years of hard work and dedication that her resolve had

been weakened. The daily grind and struggle against her own child's manipulations and abuses had left her feeling weaker by the day. If Beatrix broke now... she knew she would fail. And it felt like she could break at any moment just from her exhaustion. Her prayers for patience route and run thin. She could not go back to how things were before, no never back to when a child had controlled her every thought! She would not back down, and so, she must endure instead.

When C'yra made it to the end of the bars, she swung high enough to jump off and away. Landing hard on her feet, panting and sweating as she turned with a grin to wave. Beatrix did not smile back, only giving a tiny nod to show she recognized her. Her daughter's grin didn't melt though, she turned and ran to join a few children on the plastic suspension bridge. Good. That was progress. Beatrix held onto her moment of triumph with both hands, feeling her heart cry out at the injustice of it all instead of feeling proud. What parent would find a child behaving properly a triumph?

"Sweetheart, be careful!"

Beatrix turned to watch as another couple kneeled on the ground to speak with their child, who wiggled in place after a few more jumps. She sneered at the scene, their daughter was surely a spoiled and wretched brat if that was the way her parents chose to treat her. Coddled and wrapped in layers of cotton that would rot away in time, leaving nothing but a husk of the joy a parent should feel from their child.

But the little girl smiled and nodded, her blonde hair glinting under the sun as she finally held still. One of her mother's gently applied sunscreen to her face, and the other continued to speak. "Did you tie your shoes?"

"Yes!"

"And you know where we'll be, can you point to it?"

The little girl pointed towards the group of tables that Beatrix was sitting at. “Over there. Can I play now?”

Beatrix watched entranced, both surprised and furious at the display. It wasn’t fair. It wasn’t *fair* ! Clearly these two fools bent to the will of their daughter and yet the little girl was polite and eager to please, and it wasn’t right! Beatrix closed her eyes, breathing in slowly before pushing the air out harshly. Control. She was an adult and she would control herself. Life wasn’t fair. What did those two do to deserve such a well-behaved child? *What had she done to deserve a beast?* She quietly prayed for the strength to survive this day.

“Hey, watch it!” C’yra shouted, loud enough that Beatrix straightened up in her seat.

She watched, eyes boring into her daughter’s back and waited. She would not interfere. But C’yra had been warned of the rules and what behaviors would be unacceptable. What would be grounds for them to go home, and which ones would be grounds for punishment. Even that grated against her heart, training failing and turning instead of punishment. But, this trip to the park was already a demented and unearned reward of its own after all. A way to give her daughter a place to burn her endless energy instead of forcing her to sit with it and learn some self-control. Beatrix had tried to teach the little brat some discipline, but it had never taken. It was a copout on her part, a way to reward good behavior at home while sparing herself the misery of her daughter’s failures and never ending well of fidgeting and running and leg bouncing.

“I’m sorry, I didn’t see you.” The little blonde girl twisted her hands around in front of herself. “Are you okay?”

C’yra shrugged and mumbled her answer. Beatrix added it to the list. Mumbling was no way to speak, if one could not hear your words it was as bad as if you hadn’t spoken at all.

“I’m Adora, d’you wanna play? I’m good at the monkey bars!” Adora already turned, skipping back towards the bars.

C’yra turned with her, revealing the way she scowled at Adora’s back before saying, “I’m better!”

Ego. Public outburst.

“Oh yeah? You haven’t even seen me yet, watch!”

Adora managed to go from one end to the other, and that was about all that could really be said about that.

“Lame. Watch this!”

Name calling. Hubris. Showboating.

“That was so cool! Do it again!”

She kept count, each time C’yra misbehaved she added it to the tally. Each one another cut against her own skin, another mark proving she had failed as a mother. Every one of her daughter’s mistakes reflected poorly onto her for all to see. What must the other parents here think? What must Adora’s undeserving mothers think of her? Beatrix could feel the eyes on her back but refused to turn.

Instead she watched the two girls swing back and forth a few more times before they ran hand in hand to the swing set. Eight infractions in half as many minutes. That was on top of the rest from when they’d first arrived and C’yra had caused a scene about not being able to reach the water fountain. As if Beatrix was made of money and could replace every expensive metal reusable bottle her ungrateful child lost or destroyed. She’d been forced to kneel down onto the sunbaked concrete like some homeless beggar to show C’yra how to climb up on the fountain’s stand to drink. It had cost three counts against her, then a fourth as she remembered the way C’yra always found spots to climb in the backyard when she thought her mother wasn’t watching.

“They sure seem to be getting along well huh?” One of Adora’s mothers sat at the table with her uninvited, the woman’s dark hair pulled into a long braid and her golden earrings flashed under the sun. “I’m Mara, Adora’s mom.”

It was, like so many things, a split-second decision.

Her emotions had been destroyed by this day, and her weariness had only grown stronger as C’yra misbehaved again and again. Publicly shaming her with little more than a smirk to show for it. For a moment Beatrix considered ignoring Mara, turning away, or discussing something to drive her off. But then she caught sight of her daughter again. C’yra, who at that very moment was apologizing to Adora for some unseen infraction.
Perhaps...perhaps this could be a glorious thing. Adora could be a role model for her own miscreant. Someone to help guide and teach C’yra how to behave.

Goodness knows Beatrix had tried to teach her how to apologize but it was one of those lessons that hadn’t truly stuck. C’yra only apologizing to deflect the blame or in a twisted attempt to appease instead of genuinely conceding that her behavior had been terrible.

And if nothing else...perhaps she too could spend more time with this golden child. A good girl, a proper good girl like *she* had deserved. As pathetic as pretending would be, Beatrix was tired. And sweet, little Adora could prove to be her saving grace.

“Yes...they do seem rather taken with one another, don’t they?” Beatrix smiled. “Perhaps this is the start of a beautiful friendship.”

Chapter End Notes

> Shadow Weaver really out here expecting people to show her respect (as an ultimate be all end all authority) before she will show them any respect (as a human being), and doesn't get why she doesn't have a healthy and loving relationship with her child.

Pull back your mask and release your fury

Chapter Summary

> C’yra twitched, breath hitching for a moment as she backed up further into her room. But she never was smart enough to understand a basic set of instructions. “No, I’m a person and you- you can’t treat me like this!”
>
> It rang through the air from poisoned tongue to hang like weights from her heart. Despite the warnings, despite the training and the trying, the effort and tears and years she had poured in... she had failed.

Chapter Notes

> CHAPTER TRIGGER WARNING: This chapter ends with Weaver actually physically attacking Catra. It's mostly off screen but if you want to skip it completely make sure to stop when you see the *** (just after the line "Be silent.").
>
> Summary of the event will be in end note for those who want it, but please be aware the chapter ends with some formatting that is still part of that scene so just go straight to the end note if you want it.
>
> This will be the most graphic chapter for physical abuse. Please take care of yourselves and skip if needed. If you are worried and don't want to risk it, go to my tumblr (nny11writes.tumblr.com) and shoot me a DM, and I can give you a full chapter summary.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Beatrix sat in her car and waited, glaring through her Ray-Bans to watch as Mara and Razz gave C’yra some tupperware full of most likely unearned food. Razz tweaked her cheek as C’yra grinned and giggled, the perfect mask to fool them into thinking kindly of her. Mara tapped her own cheek and C’yra went on her tippy toes

to give her the requested kiss. When Beatrix demanded a goodnight kiss C'yra balked and shied away, like a skittish horse frightened by the snapping of a twig before responding.

It burned.

But she'd long since given up on counting every single infraction, she did not have the energy to do so anymore. At thirteen years old C'yra was *winning* , and it made Beatrix sick.

Often the only thing that seemed to have gone right had been finding her precious Adora.

As she'd hoped, when C'yra was with her friend her behavior was always better. Not because C'yra herself made it so, no she would do nothing for Beatrix (lazy, insolent, greedy), but because a quick look from Adora was like magic. There had been a moment, when C'yra first began attending middle school that Beatrix's hopes seemed dashed. C'yra's behavior worsened as the weeks dragged by, becoming more stubborn and obstinate- and crying, *still* always crying even when furious! When she'd gone to the school to learn what her daughter had done now, it inevitably turned into tears and a forced apology. At home, C'yra had tried to blame her behavior on her own mother with a brazen brashness that stung like a slap. As if she did not kindly buy C'yra new clothes, feed her, and keep her housed and safe. As if all her efforts to help her grow and mature well and correctly counted for nothing. Where she'd gotten the idea from, Beatrix would never know, but she certainly ensured that her daughter had a better respect for her mother afterwards.

She'd feared the time with Adora day in and day out was no longer enough. That now with some freedoms that came with age, C'yra would turn back into a beast before her very eyes. Somedays it almost seemed like it had happened.

And then there was Mara and Razz, who were so easily tricked that they did not believe Beatrix over C'yra. *She is a very well-behaved child, I'm sure she's just testing her limits.* Ha! Behaved?

No. Testing her limits? Well, that at least was certainly true, growing enough of a spine to sometimes flout the rules or try to avoid her punishments as long as possible. But now her bags were searched, her drawers turned out regularly for any contraband. Beatrix's computer loaded with software to ensure C'yra's cooperation. But still, she was tired and often allowed her to stay with the Grey's to find a shred of peace.

No. She was not a well-behaved child, despite their surely wishful thinking. C'yra was a very good liar after all, but only with others. Never with her. Beatrix hated it as much as she appreciated it, honesty *was* valuable in its own ways after all. But the nights she'd spent lying awake debating if she would rather her daughter obviously lie but behave well or to continue to be herself were many and long.

Adora flung her arms around C'yra, peppering her with kisses which her daughter squealed and twisted to avoid. Disgusting. Beatrix leaned on her horn and allowed herself a small smile as C'yra jumped, turning quickly to say goodbye. It was the one thing she could rely on. Like a dog. A snap of her fingers and call of her name, and C'yra would come quickly.

The back door opened as C'yra slid into her seat, placing the container of food on the floor between her feet. Hastily greeting, "Thank you for picking me up."

"I would thank you to hurry up next time, or perhaps you would prefer to remain in the garage?"

C'yra winced and shook her head. "N-no ma'am." That damn stutter had never resolved either.

She waved to the Grey's and pulled out of their disgustingly stained driveway, locking eyes with her daughter in the rear-view mirror. "Then act like it. Just because it's getting cold, do not think I will soften and allow you free reign."

"Yes ma'am." C'yra sat silent in her seat, legs bouncing and fingers tapping.

It was if the little brat knew each and every time Beatrix had a splitting headache! "What do you think you're doing then?"

There was a look of confusion on her face before C'yra paled. Her legs stilled; hands clasped together tight. "Sorry mom, I- I didn't realize I was-"

"And yet you can stop once I harass you for it? Do not lie to me child. You may be able to fool Adora's mothers, but you cannot lie to me." She carefully merged onto the highway, sighing heavily, and preparing for the grueling drive home. If it had already started this early, it would surely continue like clockwork.

"I…" C'yra started, eyes going wide as if surprised she'd started before finishing her thought. She was not supposed to speak unless spoken to, but Beatrix would rather she finish a sentence than appear like a stuttering retard. "I wa-wasn't lying, I just, I just wanted to explain. I don't mean to-"

"Ha! You never **mean** to do anything do you?" Beatrix sneered. "The least you can do when I catch you lying is own up to your actions."

"I-I-I am! I didn't mean to, but- but- but I did and I'm sorry, okay?"

Beatrix nearly ground her teeth. First she wouldn't take responsibility and now she insisted on that infuriating stuttering habit! She gripped the steering wheel tightly before hissing, "I do not appreciate your tone, and if you cannot speak properly then do not speak at all!"

C'yra's mouth clicked shut as her face scrunched with anger. Good! Let the little wretch fume for being caught. She'd burn through the anger hot and bright as always before they got home. Clearly Beatrix had become too lax if C'yra thought she could treat her like this. In the silence of the drive she noted to herself to pull

out the old doghouse, she'd need to check that the door still locked appropriately before it could be used. And at this rate it would be seeing quite a bit of use.

The rest of the drive was, blessedly, in silence.

At the house C'yra was still frowning disrespectfully but finally held her tongue. Taking her shoes off before entering and walking on the plastic protective mats to put the container on the counter.

"And where do you think you're taking that?" She asked, brown arched in exasperation. Beatrix held out her hand and dutifully, C'yra gave her the container. Which on closer inspection was nothing but cookies. As if C'yra needed any more help becoming a fat, lazy slob.

"Uhm," C'yra winced at her non-word, "Out on the- the counter for after dinner?"

"Oh? And tell me what have you done to deserve the- the cookies," She mocked, then closed her eyes to take a deep breath. Control. She needed to keep control. The little brat wanted her to lash out, to sink to her level. "Well?"

C'yra glared at the ground, teeth grinding before she huffed softly, "They made them for me."

"They made them for you."

C'yra shrunk, shoulders curling upwards as her eyes grew wide. Oh good, at least the little beast knew her tone.

"That's not what I asked you child. What did **you** do to deserve cookies after dinner?"

"Nothing ma'am."

"Pathetic. Throw them away."

C’yra’s put her hands behind her back for just a moment, a sure sign that she was squeezing them into fists before taking the container back. “Yes ma’am.”

She still waited patiently and watched as her daughter upended the whole lot into the trash. With one last command, she emptied the trash under the sink into their kitchen garbage as well. She’d caught the mongrel pawing through the leftovers a few years back when she’d lost her meal privileges, and ever since then she ensured that the trash was either emptied or the food ruined for eating.

The night was almost normal after that. C’yra washed up and made dinner and took her plate with no complaints to eat in the garage. Beatrix could keep her food from spilling and splattering on her high-end organic furniture and pristine white carpet. C’yra, on the other hand, had proven time and time again that she could not. Beatrix left her dish and utensils for her to wash later. After such a trying day she turned on the television, watching her nightly shows to unwind while listening to C’yra wash and then wipe down the kitchen.

“Can I go to my room?”

Yet the headaches never ceased. “Ask properly.”

“May I go to my room?”

“Yes, I’ll be up in a few hours to see your homework.”

Not even a half hour later she heard a single quiet burst of laughter, and with a furious growl she turned off the television. Well, there was no rest for the wicked nor those tasked to mind them. When she arrived upstairs C’yra was hunched over her desk looking at her textbook, easily spotted through the now doorless frame after C’yra had had the gall to lock her door the week before. Always hiding and sneaking, conniving and scheming. Beatrix was frayed to her very limits.

“I told you to do your homework.”

“I am.” C’yra grumbled.

She was loath to admit it, but that set her off. She’d teach her to take such a tone with her!

Stalking forward she yanked C’yra’s chair back, causing her to yelp before hauling her from her seat. Pulling its arm until it had gone up on its toes before asking in as calm a voice as she could. “What did you say?”

There was a pause as it struggled, quickly giving up. “I said yes ma’am.”

The slap had no force behind it, but it cried out as if she’d burned a mark to its cheek.

“Silence! I will not stand for this insolence you rotten little brat! You said ‘I am’, not ‘yes ma’am’. That is the second lie you have told me tonight. You must be eager to break in your crate, and I will oblige you.”

“No! I wasn’t-I’m n-not! I’m sorry mom, I really am!”

It was like an electric shock from a faulty outlet. Like burning your hand on a tray pulled from the oven hours ago. But she could not, would not react.

Calm. Controlled. Even. *Not* in the tone but in the words. “Do not back talk to me.”

“I’m not! You’re, you’re the one the one who, uhm, who, who keeps **shoving words in my mouth!**” C’yra wrenched her arm free with a growl, stumbling backwards as she went. Half shouting, “I haven’t even done anything!”

“You will not talk to me that way,” Beatrix struggled to keep her voice even and smooth as glass. Training. *Consistent Training.* “You will hold your tongue.”

C’yra twitched, breath hitching for a moment as she backed up further into her room. But she never was smart enough to understand a basic set of instructions. “No, I’m a *person* and you- you can’t treat me like this!”

It rang through the air from poisoned tongue to hang like weights from her heart. Despite the warnings, despite the training and the trying, the effort and tears and **years** she had poured in... she had failed.

Beatrix watched her daughter for just a moment, on the edge of giving up entirely. She had failed this day and there was no saving it. C’yra would sleep in the garage for at least the night to bring some peace, but Beatrix had no more energy left to stand tall in the wake of the abuse. But then she saw the girl relax just a fraction of a hair. How could she forget? From the start, back when C’yra had been sub-human, back when Beatrix had known the truth of her, she had known her daughter was manipulative. Crying for no reason, tears and pleas to try and force her own mother- oh her demon had done its best to break her soul. Now, more human than beast Beatrix had forgotten that the names she called her by were not descriptors but truths.

C’yra’s behavior had only gotten worse as the years progressed, snickering at her struggles over fang like teeth. No. There was no training anymore was there? No animal was untrainable, but her daughter had never been true flesh and blood, had she? No, no no no. If it wished to thrash and bite, then she would treat it like any other violent creature. Clearly, she had been too soft, used too delicate of a touch to be understood and respected. Fine.

If she wanted Beatrix to be the bad guy, then she’d become a witch.

“Understand that your actions are your own. But to have even made these choices, I have failed you. I have tried to teach you, I have tried to help you grow strong, stronger than me, stronger than any. And I failed you. ...but if this is the price, then it must

be paid. You have **hurt** me C'yra, and these are the consequences."

C'yra's eyes widened, body tensing as she was cornered in her own room. "M-mom, no, it, wait-"

"Be silent."

***

"Please, please I'm, I'm s-sorry I-"

She closed her ears to the false suffering, blinded her eyes of the illusion. Beatrix had vowed to win this battle of wills. If her daughter was truly so obstinate and worthless as to be untrainable, then Beatrix would truly punish instead. It was a failure of her's to bear, and so she let herself ignore the pleas to focus on what needed to be done. Beatrix would persevere. She would be damned before she conceded, she would never give in. Her awareness tightened to the harshness of the air in her lungs and the burn of her arms. Her vision darkened and Beatrix wouldn't stop. Vowing to continue until her instructions were followed, she would stop when C'yra stopped her pathetic crying.

And she could still hear the sound.

C'yra wouldn't stop so why would she? Beatrix had truly been as stalwart as she could be, she had been kind and lenient, and now that must change. C'yra could learn something yet. If she'd thought Beatrix had been cruel before, well then, she would show her just how wrong she had been! But it doesn't listen, and it doesn't stop! So, neither will she!

But **It** doesn't stop.

And It **doesn't** stop.

And It doesn't **stop**.

And It doesn't stop, and It doesn't stop, and It doesn't stop, and It doesn't stop, And It doesn't stop, And It doesn't stop, And It doesn't stop, And It doesn't stop, AND It doesn't stop AND It doesn't stop AND It doesn't stopAND It doesn't STOPAND It DOESN'T STOP AND IT DOESN'T stopANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPAND**IT** DOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOP *I'MSORRY* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'T *PLEASE* STOPANDIT**DOESN'T** STOPANDITDOESN'T *PLEASE* STOPANDITDOESN'TSTOP*ITHURTS* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDIT**DOESN'T** STOPANDITDOESN'TPLEASE**STOP** ANDITDOESN'T**STOP** ANDITDOESN'TSTOP*IWON'TDOITAGAIN* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'T *PLEASESTOP* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOP *MOMI'MSORRY* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPAND**ITDOESN'T** STOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDI **DOESN'TSTOP** ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOP *IPROMISEIPROMISEIWON'T* ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'T**STOP** ANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'TSTOPANDITDOESN'T**STOP**ANDITDOESN'TSTOP*IMSORRY*ANDITDOESN'TSTOPA

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A N D I T D O E S N ` T **E V E R**
E N D

Until it does.

Chapter End Notes

End scene summary:

Weaver makes the conscious decision to start physically abusing Catra by beating her. She frames it as if she is loosing control of herself/that she is being forced to do it by Catra.

End formatting is one part the physical attack and one part time lapse, showing that Weaver doesn't stop once she's chosen to do this with the implication that she is the reason this perpetuates and she /could/ stop at any time. The chapter ends with a single line stating that the abuse does end.

Don’t venture into the forest, my dear (The trees will trick you and lose you my dear)

Chapter Summary

> “I will expect it in my inbox within two days, and you will call me tomorrow-”
>
> “When I get up, at lunch, and before I go to bed, I know. I’ll be texting before going to each class too. I do remember the rules.”
>
> “Try. Again.”
>
> “I...yes. I promise I will call and text you tomorrow to make sure I’m he-mmm,” C’yra cleared her throat again, such a disgusting habit, “that I’m alright. I promise.”

Chapter Notes

> CW: There is a brief allusion to physical abuse in the section starting with "The weekend visit had been terse." Please skip if you need to, nothing will be lost.
>
> Additionally, this chapter includes some very controlling behaviors and financial abuse related to Catra going to college. If that's is triggering for you, you may want to skip this chapter.
>
> I will include a chapter summary at the bottom for those who need/want it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Well that’s good then,” Beatrix nodded, her phone held tightly between cheek and shoulder as she continued to cook. “Although I’m sure you loved the trouble it caused.”

C’yra doesn’t laugh. There’s no sound for a split second too long and she wanted nothing more than to snap her ungrateful daughter’s neck. Instead she forced her hand to relax around the wooden spoon and concentrated on the way it felt as she scraped the bottom of the pot. Carefully pushing the onions and garlic around and around.

“We, ahem, we were able to work it out though.” C’yra’s voice could sound almost confident to anyone who didn’t know how to hear the hollowness in it. “They put me in Philosophy 101 instead. So, I’m still on track- and I’m on the waitlist for English. See? Nothing to worry about!”

Beatrix frowned as she carefully poured in the quarter cup of red wine, deglazing the pot from the pork chops before pouring in a can of tomato sauce. “Nothing except your future.”

“Well we both know I’ll fail at that.” C’yra had learned her place, but nothing she’d ever done could teach that girl to bite her damn tongue.

Frankly, Beatrix was amazed that someone as lazy and pathetically undeserving as her was accepted into college. Especially considering how late she had submitted her application and FAFSA. No scholarships and no work study, but it was the best university in-state. Prestigious and an R1 research institution to boot. While furious over the money she was forced to pay Beatrix knew that it was an investment that would pay off. C’yra was only two hours away by car, an easy day trip for surprise inspections at her student dorm. Contraband was, after all, still contraband.

The dorm was something they’d discussed and agreed to, it was required for C’yra to live on campus for her freshman year and after that she would return to live at home to save Beatrix the gas money and commute time. The trains would take her back and forth well enough and her schedule would be built around her job allowing her to only make the trip a few times a week. Beatrix had already signed and submitted the release form granting her access to view her daughter's grades, something which was

unnecessary since C'yra was still claimed as her dependent. But redundancies were unfortunately required when it came to her child.

As much as Beatrix didn't trust her daughter, especially with such a distance forced between them, she trusted the girl's untrustworthiness and knew to play off of that. She'd made sure to get a promise from C'yra to call that night before leaving, twisting it from a reluctant throat of course, but trust it she did with the understanding being; you wouldn't want to make me drive back out tomorrow to take you home for good would you? No. She wouldn't, especially not when it would embarrass her in front of Adora.

That had truly been the only reason Beatrix allowed C'yra to even go to FZSU when she learned about the dorm situation. Adora had agreed to be C'yra's dorm mate, and the two had filed together for the space. Adora had sense, Adora had drive, and Adora had proven to be one of the only people who could keep her daughter on a tight enough leash.

So Beatrix, cautiously, agreed.

She already regretted that choice, even as she reveled in the luxury of having her home back to herself. Home was a refuge after all, one that Beatrix had been missing for eighteen long years. Her home once more quiet and sanctified, once more truly her place of rest instead of her prison. She took a deep breath in as she fought her desire to shout, instead pouring in the waiting chicken broth to have something to focus on. She was here and safe, and C'yra was where she should be. Where she needed to be.

"Do not be flippant with me child, I can pull my funding at any time I please. You will not be a college dropout and you **will** repay me what was lent."

"Yes mom," C'yra half mumbled.

She took a moment to gently toss in the remaining spices before covering the sauce with a lid. “Try again.”

There was an almost painfully loud throat clearing before C’yra answered clearly, “Yes mom, I’m sorry.”

God she was so tired of the sarcasm, the drama, and the manipulation. The timer was set for two hours and Beatrix let the silence drag on uncomfortably long knowing that it would be a more effective tool than any words.

Her daughter’s weak will would never outlast her own. Not anymore. “Ah, I really am. ...mom, are you there?”

“You are very fortunate you know? To be where you are,” Beatrix paused letting her truth get across before continuing, “Many people would die to attend such a good school. You will make the most of this, am I understood?”

“Yes ma’am, I understand.”

Beatrix switched the phone to her right ear as she grabbed her glass of wine, opening her email app on her tablet with a frown. “We will see. C’yra, why haven’t you sent me your schedule yet?”

“Seriously? I just told-ugh, there was a problem with my account *mother* . My NetID was linked to an email but not to my Student ID, and it will take 48 hours before I can actually access my account at all. That’s why I couldn’t register before I got here and met with an advisor.”

A likely story. “I will expect it in my inbox within two days, and you will call me tomorrow-”

“When I get up, at lunch, and before I go to bed, I know. I’ll be texting before going to each class too. I do remember the rules.”

“Try. Again.”

"I...yes. I promise I will call and text you tomorrow to make sure I'm he-mmm," C'yra cleared her throat again, such a **disgusting** habit, "that I'm alright. I promise."

And that, that she could trust. So, she said goodnight and enjoyed her very first evening without anger and fear and loathing.

She truly could get used to this.

[Missed Call | 7:02 AM | C'yra]

Voicemail Transcript

Good morning mom I was just calling like you asked to let you know I'm awake and ____ so that's a thing I get. I ____ sainsbury. Hey in the future I'm gonna wait until I'm not a yummy missed a call like 10 minutes ok? Save us both from them he when I'm when I'm ____. ____. Text you soon. Bye.

[Was this helpful? Yes No]

C'yra

Today 8:27 AM
@ hist101

2 row

Just fyi i guess

Today 9:54 AM

omw to calc

What do you mean “on your way”?

Your class starts in five minutes.

C’yra?

hyh was @ the wrong bldg

We will talk about this

Today 10:43 AM

joy

Try again, and do not text in class.

yes ma'am & we let out early ma’am.

You are not half as clever as you think.

Do not forget you are coming home for the weekend. We will talk then.

Today 12:07 PM

Yes mom. I'm eating lunch with Adora and my new study buddy.

Can I call you after?

Barely a minute passed before her phone gave another feeble alert.

Adora Grey

Today 12:08 PM
Hello Ms. Weaver! Just letting you know that C'yra and I are having lunch with a girl from our calculus class. She asked me to text you and let you know.

Beatrix looked at the photo she'd sent carefully. Adora had taken a selfie, showing C'yra sitting behind her talking with a vaguely familiar disgusting girl with pink and purple dyed hair. They were sitting at a table in front of a seal with FZSU's robot mascot glaring menacingly down at them, on the table she could see a textbook out and a plate of pizza slices. Beatrix knew she needed to add keeping distance from the harlot with unnatural hair to her ever-growing list of reminders, along with reminding C'yra to watch her food. No daughter of hers would gain the Freshman Fifteen, especially not one who was ugly enough as is; let alone if she developed a second chin like her new "study buddy".

Still, C'yra was keeping to the schedule. And that *was* the most important thing.

Beatrix refreshed her email again before checking the clock. It had now been 52 hours since C'yra's ID issue had been addressed, and four hours since it was supposed to have been fixed. And despite having kept to the check in schedule, her

wayward child had now “forgotten” to send her schedule as promised.

She reached for her phone right as an email arrived.

A full 18 credit hours looked back at her, several classes which C’yra should have already finished if she had simply applied herself harder in her AP classes were displayed next to some of her common core that everyone had to take.

When her phone rang Beatrix made sure to emphasize her displeasure, “Toeing the line as always I see.”

C’yra’s huffing signaled the end to what had been a perfectly good day. Ruined!

More to add onto the weekend.

The weekend visit had been terse. Beatrix asked her questions before presenting her list of infractions. C’yra clenched her jaw and hands, looking away before angrily turning around.

Which spared them at least one tired argument.

When Beatrix went to bed early from a migraine, which she was sure C’yra’s mere presence had set off, she still made sure to stretch her arms and wrists. She hadn’t really been so strict in a while, so it was necessary to avoid cramps and soreness the next day.

She had to say though, overall, it went very well all things considered.

Beatrix had taken her time after getting home nearly a week later. Fridays were always hellish at the office, and knowing that she would be forced to deal with C'yra again in person within twenty hours...well, she deserved a little spoiling didn't she? She'd showered before relaxing in a warm bath, a book and a glass of wine happily consumed while she enjoyed her treat.

An unintentional treat for her daughter as well, she supposed. Her phone had been left on the bed along with her favorite pajamas, so they'd miss their nightly check in. Normally this would have been cause for more concern, but C'yra had managed to behave for the better part of the week and Beatrix admitted she was getting soft with distance.

Hours later she was dressed, had eaten dinner, and stretched out on the couch before pulling her phone out. There was no voicemail. She glanced at the time on her phone, then checked again on the digital clock. 8:30 PM. C'yra was three *hours* late. And as with all things that Beatrix enjoyed, as with every time she considered using a softer touch, her daughter managed to sour it.

She tapped a finger irritably against her popsocket as she waited for C'yra to answer her call. And waited. And waited. And went to voicemail. Beatrix furiously called again with the same results. Then again.

"C'yra you will answer your phone, this behavior is unacceptable!"

"Answer your phone or there will be consequences."

She left silence on the third voicemail.

"Last chance."

No answer. No email. Nothing. Nothing at all.

God take it all she refused to drive down there after having such a wonderful evening! All her weekend plans now ruined as she

figured out how to handle her insolent child. Always making it about her, her, her! Never considering how her actions affected those around her!

"We will speak tomorrow C'yra."

But she never arrived.

The school offices were closed on weekends, it turned out. Sunday found Beatrix calling every office from the Dean of Students to the Student Housing Department before deciding that as with all things she would simply have to do it herself. She quickly emailed her supervisor and took Monday off.

They **would** talk.

"There must be some mistake, we both signed the consent form before C'yra came for orientation!" Beatrix snapped, eyes flashing at the man who was supposed to be assisting her. "I am trying to ascertain the wellbeing of my daughter."

"I understand that ma'am, but unfortunately due to FERPA laws, I am not allowed to give you any information about a student that is not listed in the directory without that consent form on file."

“She is my dependent! I don’t need the stupid form, I’m merely upset that it’s been lost!”

The man nodded, his disarming smile only becoming more and more grating as their conversation continued. “I understand that may have been the plan, but according to our files C’yra filed independently during the last tax season. I am sorry ma’am, all we can do is wait for the university police to check her dorm, which they already are.”

Beatrix seethed; she **knew** that. This obstinate bastard had been sure to remind her of that fact every five minutes since they’d first met nearly an hour ago!

“So, I’m just supposed to sit here quietly until they return?”

“You don’t have to stay here if you would prefer to wait in the lobby, I would be happy to-”

“And let you become distracted by some other **far** less pressing case? I think not!”

“Of course; it is your choice ma’am.”

Beatrix felt her ears ringing. “What?”

The officers paused, before continuing, “There was no student by that name in the dorms Ms. Weaver.”

The bore of a man who’d been helping her no longer wore his foolish smile, instead frowning as he spoke up, “It appears that C’yra Weaver did pay for a dorm-”

“ ***I*** paid for her dorm!”

He continued ignoring her completely, “And was registered for classes until this past Saturday when she dropped them.”

“Nonsense, if she’d dropped her classes my bank account would have been refunded!”

The man glanced at the officers before focusing on her. “They appear to have been dropped after the refund deadline, and she has taken a W for withdrawal for all of her courses.”

“If she dropped those classes I want my money back, I paid for them! I wish to withdraw her from this school and demand a refund for her dorm as well!”

“I understand ma’am, Officer Fox? Can you please show Ms. Weaver to the Financial Aid Office so she can discuss the matter with them?”

“Please calm down-”

“MY CHILD IS MISSING, I’VE LOST ALMOST TEN THOUSAND DOLLARS, AND YOU WANT ME TO CALM DOWN?”

“Ma’am, I will have to call security if you continue-”

“CALL THEM!”

Beatrix sat fuming in her car across the street from the main campus. Officer Fox sat on a bench and waved cheerfully at her.

C’yra was gone. Not missing, oh no, when they’d managed to contact the RA who had found a letter left in the wrong mail cubby with C’yra’s name written on the back. One written and signed by her daughter with a very special message.

“To Whom it May Concern and My Bitch of a Mother:

Yes I dropped my classes, I do not plan to attend this university at this time and have withdrawn from my classes as I was advised to do by the Dean of Students Office in order to fully withdraw as a student from this institution. I understand that my tuition, fees, and dorm cannot be refunded. I am, in fact, grateful that they cannot be refunded.

Enjoy the credit card debt “mom”.

And I’ll enjoy the rest of my life free from you. Don’t bother filing for a missing person, I’m not missing, I left willingly and under my own power.

Sincerely (Formerly),

C’yra Weaver”

She’d been re-reading it over and over as if it would give her all the answers she sought. It had been several hours since she’d been told to leave. Hours of burning through her rage until she was hollow.

She’d known the moment that creature was born that C’yra was not a real daughter, but a punishment. Beatrix had been certain her perseverance would be rewarded. That her efforts would not be in vain. That she had done **well** . She had been wrong. No. No! No, there must be something she’s missed. She read the letter again before pausing halfway through. No one was in that dorm. That’s what they’d said. No one. All the fury turned to dread. Not even sweet, wonderful Adora.

She dialed Mara. “Did you know that your daughter is not at university?”

“Hello Beatrix.” She’d never heard Mara’s voice so cold before. “Yes, in fact I did. We spoke before she dropped her classes.”

“Where is she?”

“You don’t need to know.”

Beatrix slammed her hand down on the steering wheel, pushing herself far into her seat as she hissed, “I do when she’s run away with my daughter!”

“No, actually you still don’t need to know. You’ve never really been that girl’s mother and unlike you, I don’t hurt children.”

“...what?” No. No, no, no! She wouldn’t have, C’yra wouldn’t have told such- such **lies** ! “How dare you, I have been strict-”

“YOU HURT HER! You were slick about it alright, ooh, you were. You had us all fooled, but she showed us what you’ve done and Adora backed her up. And you think that I’D help YOU?” Mara scoffed. “They’re adults now Weaver. And you won’t find them, so just give up.”

Her breathing had gone strangled and off. Beatrix couldn’t breathe. She couldn’t *think.* “You know where they are!”

“In fact, I don’t. I gave them money, sold them my old outback, and I told them not to tell me a damned thing. Also? Don’t bother trying to find C’yra by her cell phone location. First thing we had her do was throw that thing away. I’m not telling you this to make your life easier, I’m doing it to make you understand it’s over.” There was a long pause before Mara spoke again. “You are lucky that girl isn’t pressing charges. Don’t press that luck any further.”

“Are you threatening me?”

Mara laughed and the line cut. Her call back was ignored. The second time she tried, a robot answered. “ *This number is not currently in service or has been disconnected. Please check the number and try again later.* ”

Beatrix stared unseeing out the window until long after the sun had set. Then, finally, with as much grace as she could muster, she started her car and pulled away.

When she arrived home hours later, she sat in the dark, silent living room and knew that she had failed. Worse, that she had been wrong. She had thought being given C’yra had been a curse, and in its way it had been, but it wasn’t her punishment. Her fear of humiliation, her desire for money, her drive to have a child worthy of being praised and presented...all twisted in on themselves. Somehow, she had lost the power she had, she had lost the war of wills, she had gone in debt for the ungrateful brat, and now...now she had nothing left to show for it.

C’yra had been a monster, but a familiar one. One that brought comfort to her through repetition. And she was gone.

And Beatrix couldn’t help but wonder, where had she gone so wrong as to deserve this?

Chapter End Notes

Chapter Summary: C'yra starts her freshman year at FZU where she is forced to stay on campus her first year and she agrees to dorm with Adora. Beatrix reluctantly allows her to go because she fully expects Adora to keep C'yra in line, and that her investment in her daughter's education will pay for itself. Two weeks into the semester C'yra stops her required check ins and Beatrix goes to FZU to sort her out, only to learn that C'yra dropped all her classes just after the deadline for refunds and has left a note explaining that she left willingly. Beatrix calls Mara to try and get her daughter's location, and finds out that they had help from Adora's mom's to leave and escape from her. She frames this as something terrible that's happened to her, and she doesn't understand what she could've done to deserve it.

So who's ready for the epilogue from Catra's perspective set about a decade from now?

Epilogue: You need not dig a grave

Chapter Summary

It wasn’t perfect.

But god if she wasn’t happy.

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the end of the fic everyone, enjoy Catra's PoV and her great, dumb wife. :)

CW: Mild suicidal ideation and brief descriptions of an emotional breakdown. Middle section includes some time at a psychiatric ward starting after "To see all the people she cared about in one place, to realize just how many people cared about her." and ending at "She’d mentioned it glumly to Adora".

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra slowly put the cap back on the milk before shoving it into the fridge hard enough to knock something over. There was no space to be delicate this ungodly early in the fucking morning. Or, well, evening but when you work night shifts time doesn’t exist and reality seems more like a suggestion on a good day. She groaned and took a drag from her mug of coffee. It was waaaaaay too early to be getting into the weeds already.

“Ooooh, aren’t you just bright eyed and bushy tailed?” Adora chuckled, arms gently wrapping around Catra’s hips to pull her backwards into a hug.

“Eat a dick.”

One hand pinched her hip before Adora grumbled into her shoulder, “Oh shush, drink your lightly caffeinated milk. You’ll be in a better mood once it hits your brain, jerk.”

Catra hummed, took another drink, and yawned. God she was fucking tired. “How’syer day?”

“Ugh, UGH- just, arrgugh! Light Hope said I need to start meditating again. Can you believe that? She **knows** I hate it! It’s just, it’s like I’m wasting time you know? And- I know, I know I just need to work up to it. I still hate it and it doesn't work! Can’t I just look after a fish? Grow something? Be the lesbian farmer I want to see in the world?”

Catra frowned, yeah meditation was sucky hard but when Adora actually did it for the thirty minute minimum she *was* much more calm and focused. She still nodded her head a little to appease her wife before cursing and trying to detangle from Adora’s ridiculously ripped arms. Because, well, speaking of therapist approved...

“Noooo, Catra, I see you for a few hours a day. A few hours! When we’re both awake it’s snuggling time, you can’t leave!” Adora went limp, and nearly dragged them both to the floor.

Catra barely managed to not slosh hot coffee everywhere as she desperately kept her footing. She grunted, “Babe I love you, but I need to take my meds or else I’ll be a total bitch at work.”

All this managed to do was get Adora back on her feet, where she then proceeded to shuffle them both physically back to the counter where Catra’s pill box was like she was a baby learning to dance on someone's shoes. Catra rolled her eyes and grabbed it anyways, ignoring the little ninja stickers that Adora had stuck all over it ‘to make it less old lady like’, and quickly popped her assortment of medications like a pro. With Adora still nuzzling into her neck and shoulder, and standing in their kitchen, it was hard to even fake a frown.

It was moments like these that Catra really appreciated. Being home alone with her wife of eight years, proving she was a living human being by holding down a job and taking care of herself. It was pathetically little, as far as lofty goals or big dreams went. It

was more than she'd ever thought she'd have. Maybe more than she really deserved, but Catra was willfully greedy like that.

"Oh fuck me," Catra muttered, very much annoyed and embarrassed to have to do this in front of someone, but it was Adora, and maybe it would help? Note to self, tell therapist. "My dreams aren't stupid; I deserve happiness and I'm not greedy for wanting it. See Adora? I did my homework unlike **some** people, who I won't name to preserve their anonymity-"

Adora groaned, shifting to burying her nose in Catra's hair and whined, "I dunwanna!"

"Baby."

"Takes one to know one."

"Ouch, deflection from the fact that you aren't meditating? You wound me; look I'll be crying for days now."

Adora squeezed her tighter as she growled, "It's so boring! What does she think will happen? I'm always running at least five trains of thought and trying to not focus on any of them makes them CRASH AT THE STATION. It blows!"

"You meditate on the reg and I'll blow you on the reg."

"I… that... that might be the most effective threat you've ever given me."

"I know you, and you think evil is hot. Threats are the only way I get anything done with you, dork. Besides I like you, or some bullshit, so I guess I should help."

Adora laughed, pulling back just far enough to rock them both from one foot to the other. "Awww, you like me? How embarrassing for you!"

"Babe, we're married."

Adora pressed a kiss to the corner of her jaw, “Still.”

God she could die happy. It had taken twelve years to get here, but it had been worth it.

Back when she was seventeen and thought she’d live and die under Weaver’s boot, back when Adora and her moms were the only good thing in her life, she couldn’t have pictured this. She’d been so scared when they found out. Catra hadn’t even been thinking as she took her hoodie off and her shirt lifted a scant inche, which wouldn’t be a problem normally except she’d lost weight that month and not been able to afford a new belt to keep her stupid pants up at her waist. Razz’s scream had scared the shit out of her. When she whipped around, she found Razz staring at her so sadly through her coke bottle glasses her wheezed, “Oh deary, who hurt you?” had felt like the end of the world.

No amount of denial or growling had helped, and the world had somehow shrunk and grown as she realized that the Grey's had always suspected something. Someone. There's a blank period and the next thing she knew, Mara and Adora had practically boxed her in until she had a complete meltdown in their kitchen. Yelling and cursing, lashing out to the point that she broke anything in arms reach, but she really only remembered hurling their glass fruit dish at the wall. They’d all seen Catra breakdown before. Hell, Adora had even had to deal with her fury when she had accidentally ripped the lining of Catra’s coat open and some of her limited supplies had fallen out. The three of them knew what she could do when upset or hurt. But no one had seen anything like this before. For all she hissed and spit and snarled, they waited until she’d burned through the worst of it. Adora hugged her and cried as if she’d just heard Catra was *dying* instead of learning about a few ancient cuts and a half-healed bruise.

It took a lot of begging and pleading for them to not call the cops. No way would Weaver actually get locked up for life and anything less was a death sentence.

But Adora had gotten her planning skills from Mara, and between the two of them, they came up with a plan. A really fucking amazing plan once Catra had been able to listen to them and think about it. Which looking back she wished would've taken less time, but she just...hadn't been ready. Not that day as she furiously sobbed on the glass covered floor, not the week after when she tried to avoid them, not even months later when she'd finally been willing to go back but refused to apologize. She'd needed time and they gave it to her, she could still be pissed at how long it took her to actually get on board. T he four of them had worked quietly on pins and needles for almost a year before it could go into action. It was complex enough that Catra had caved and even asked Adora's preppy loser friends for help.

Thank god her mom had never been allowed too far into Adora's life, no amount of pushing had moved Mara or Razz and so her little troop of High School Musical rejects was unknown. And it turned out that Bow had a devious mind and Glimmer had a chip big enough to rival Catra's at times, and they'd both been thrilled to help even without all the details.

"You're a total bitch," Glimmer had explained over boba one afternoon, "but your mom? She's Satan's asshole incarnate. My mom almost punched her at the last parent teacher! My mom! So fuck her, if she doesn't appreciate you she can fuck off."

"Aw, you appreciate me?" Catra had asked in the most annoying voice she could while squeezing Glimmer's cup to fuck with her. Mostly to stop herself from crying outright.

Glimmer had sighed theatrically, "You dumb, dumb, dumb-dumb. I wouldn't put up with you if I didn't like you, we're not, like, *fake* friends."

That had ruined the whole thing as Catra did burst into tears, scaring the hell out Glimmer. Bow and Adora had wrapped them all up in a group hug and this time when he declared, "Best Friend Squad looks out for our own!" she realized for the very first time

ever that she was, in fact, part of that. Not an awkward hanger on. Not a third wheel. But part of them.

Another thing she'd probably always regret was not believing in her friends, refusing to even see them as *her* friends instead of Adora's. Hindsight was truly a toe sucker.

And then it was time to put their plan into action.

Her lone two weeks of college had been wild. Between still planning on running away, Adora dropping out early to help prepare everything, and realizing that she actually really liked going to school, it had been a whirlwind of activity. After going back to her dorm for the second week, wincing with every step as her back screamed murder at her, Catra considered calling it off. Weaver would always find her. She'd always, always find her and if this was the punishment just for having a little attitude in her texts, Weaver would shoot her on sight when she finally dragged her back kicking and screaming. She'd find out who helped and she'd go after them. Catra would be responsible for ruining the Grey's lives and her friends lives, and it wouldn't have even been worth it because they would've been hurt trying to help a fucking lost cause.

She'd been so wrapped up in the pain and fear, that when she tripped on the curb and collapsed Catra hadn't even realized there was someone else there until they caught her.

Scorpia was the personification of a dopey and loveable pit bull, and that was saying something considering the fact that she knew Adora. With Scorpia gingerly helping her to her dorm, it had only seemed right to invite her in. At the time she had thought it was a huge mistake when Scorpia started calling them the Super Pal Duo, but it turned out to be one of the best things to ever happen to her. Besides just being an amazing person, Scorpia had a best friend living a few states over who happened to already run a successful business. Her friend who happened to agree, without background checks or anything else, to hire her and Adora for as long as they wanted to work for her robotics company. Which was

about a thousand times better than the fast food applications they'd been preparing to submit before driving in a random direction to live out of their car.

The plan changed but the deadline didn't, and suddenly it was happening.

Her hands had been shaking with fear when she'd tucked her handwritten and signed letter into her own mail cubby and five hours into the drive they were shaking again. This time it was for all the right reasons. So, while alternating face time with Scorpia on her phone and the wonder twins on Adora's, blasting a mix of No Doubt and Eve 6, Catra let herself believe that it would work out. For the first time ever, she let herself trust that things really would be okay.

They spent one night sleeping in the car, curled up together in the back, and whispered their new plans to one another under the milky way.

Entrapta, it turned out, was *weird* . Good weird. And the job was actually kinda cool to talk about, even if the reality of excel and monotonous work often left Catra whining and hiding. Entrapta never seemed to care, despite Adora warning her that they'd get fired whenever Catra was caught slacking off or playing with the robots, Entrapta always seemed happy to see her.

"Oh good, you're here!" She'd squeal, as if they'd planned on meeting instead of Entrapta finding Catra hiding in the suspiciously large vents. Hell, one time Entrapta had dropped a note on her *from* said vents to meet her just a few rooms over and it resulted in her getting to abandon her spreadsheets for a few days in place of getting to listen to a literal genius who wanted a sounding board. She probably got a semester's worth of electrical engineering under her belt in the span of a week.

Things really were getting better.

Of course it wasn't perfect. Being away they were careful with contact back home. Scorpia had come out to visit, bringing letters from Mara and Razz and enough baked goods that Catra actually made herself sick from eating too many, and then promptly learned nothing from the experience and gorged again the next day to the same results. Scorpia's visits were invaluable as a lifeline to their friends and the Grey's, but they were also invaluable just for getting to spend time with Scorpia. In large part because Adora rarely got to just hang out with them, their slap dash friendship formed mostly over the internet and phone calls so Adora would cover for her at work. Catra was making her own friends for the first time since she'd met Adora at the park. She never told Scorpia how much it meant, but she had a feeling she was understood anyways. Each time Scorpia came out she would just chuckle, throwing an arm around her and Entrapta, "Oh man look at us, Super Pal Trio! We are just three peas in a pod!" and then eat another slice of Razz's pie while ignoring Catra hissing at her for it.

Catra had tried to lord her new status over Adora's head until she found out that, while genuine, Scorpia also called any group that was her and two other people a 'super pal trio'.

"Yeah, well, fuck you, it's not THE Super Pal Trio! We've got a special bond Adora and we show it through *capitalization*!"

Their first winter was with the Super Pal Trio and the next two also included the Best Friend Squad coming out to be with them. On their fourth year away they decided that it was finally safe enough to bring out the family. Mara and Razz arrived in a flurry of hugs and squeezes and kisses for them both as if they'd been soldiers deployed to a damn combat zone instead of two college dropouts playing with robots. It had still been so nice, so warming, so damn *much*. To see all the people she cared about in one place, to realize just how many people cared about her. To be overwhelmed with love like she was living in a Hallmark made for TV movie.

So, of course, Catra had a massive fucking meltdown like the fucked up little monster she was, and the holiday's ended with Catra sniffling in her free scratchy brown tee-shirt and teal pants on the ward. Two sets of locking doors and a nurse behind protective glass standing between her and freedom. Not that she'd been in her right mind to notice on her way in, no. She'd alternated between pacing and curling up in her plastic chair at psychiatric emergency services, swinging wildly and violently between wanting to die and wanting to go home. When the doc finally made it to her room Catra had been sure she'd never leave again. It would be her and the man singing scripture and the woman screaming expletives trapped in their little windowless, concrete rooms under camera surveillance forever. At some point she was brought further back behind the locking doors and put into her little room.

It...it had been one of the worst things that had happened to her. It had felt like hell, like everyone was throwing her away because she was finally too much for them to handle. She'd felt vindicated in some ways that the shoe had finally dropped and terrified they'd never come back. Constantly watching the other patients, especially after one of them attacked an orderly. The ward was freezing and loud and dangerous. Her five minutes in the quiet room at a time was never enough to let her actually decompress. The phone calls were short and monitored. It felt like she couldn't fucking breathe.

The best thing to happen there was that her therapist was some kind of hippie chick who slowly convinced her to finally get on medication, something she hadn't even known she'd needed and despite her initial reluctance it had ended up helping contain the background radiation in her stupid brain .

"What no essential oils for crazy people?" Catra had sneered.

Perfuma had smiled at her, pen tapping on her notebook. "You can use aloe vera for burns, and peppermint for an upset stomach. But you still need a vaccination for the flu. This is no

different and it’s not a shameful thing. You know, I take medication for my anxiety, it's one of five I take every day.”

“You’re not selling it better with that.”

She'd had the balls to giggle at that. “I'm not trying to sell you anything Catra. It's not a magic bullet, but it can be a life preserver to help keep your head above water. We won't force you to take them, it's just a tool that you could benefit from. Will you at least give it a chance?”

“...can I skip your stupid yoga class if I do?”

Eventually Catra found herself, somehow, on several different medications, going to Perfuma’s biweekly meditation seminars, and doing group yoga therapy willingly. It still wasn’t sunshine and rainbows, her sleep was fucked, and the meds had left her unable to keep much down either. But at least she didn’t want to kill herself even if she still wanted to die and spent days at a time alternating between crying like a baby and feeling nothing at all. It was still awful and scary, but slowly things got better. Well, for as much as anything could be called better in a hell hole where she couldn’t even get a glass of fucking *water* on her own. The best part of her time there was that Adora visited almost every other day, even when Catra had refused to see her for that first week, she still showed up with a hopeful smile.

It wasn’t nice. Don’t make any mistakes about that. It wasn’t nice or pleasant, there was nothing enjoyable about her time there.

But it was good for her in a way that was hard to explain.

Enough so that on the day she was being released Catra almost pulled a stunt to stay longer. Keep the routine as uncomfortable as it was in case it turned out she was just as awful and fucked as she knew she was. Instead Perfuma had found her, meditated with her, and encouraged her to get a pet of all things while escorting her out.

Catra had fiddled with the now empty plastic bin all her clothes had been shoved into on arrival. Giving it to the person at the front desk as she let Perfuma walk her through each set of security doors. "I can't even take care of myself, how am I supposed to care for some dumb animal?"

Perfuma had smiled at her softly. "But you *can* take care of yourself. You're just learning how to ask for help when you need it, the same as anyone else. And as far as a pet goes...I'm going out on a limb, so let me know if I'm overstepping, but I assume you like cats yes?"

She should've never told her about the name change, but she hadn't wanted to get in legal trouble and go to jail or something because of an old alias. Not that she knew what the consequences were, but they had to be bad right? God, and then she took stupid Adora's childhood nickname before stealing her last name, and made them her legal name like an idiot. Fucking everyone thought they had a good fucking cat joke!

...but yeah, she'd shrugged, she *did* like the few cats she'd met.

Catra had mentioned it glumly to Adora that evening at the dinner table, nervously bouncing her legs and terrified that she was going to get yelled at any second now for it. Worrying about spilling her drink or knocking her plate and making yet another mess for someone else to clean up. Adora had tilted her head in thought, face screwed up and Catra had almost burst into tears. It turned out while her life had been better than ever for four whole years, that Catra had gotten very good at lying to herself about how she was. Because if it wasn't a ruthless, evil bitch trying to beat her to death then apparently in her mind it wasn't a 'big deal'. On the other side of two shit months she was starting to realize how much she'd been stuffing down to pretend she was dealing with it. Perfuma had said something about needing to feel safe before she could process, which just sounded like an excuse to be a lazy bastard about it. But, man, realizing that she was waiting for Adora to **yell** at her had been a fucking lightning strike.

They'd gone to the couch and then to bed wrapped up together. Catra rambled and Adora listened, and then they cried themselves out for the evening.

The next day Adora took her to the shelter where they found a giant black cat with a ridiculously large roll of skin and fur at his neck that looked kind of like a feather boa. They were warned that he could get really mean and bite or swipe. But Melog had taken one look at her, walked over and flopped into her lap, and then hissed at anyone who tried to move him.

Catra could almost kiss Perfuma for the pet suggestion.

After a year with them, Melog was freakishly in tune with her. Following her room to room and reacting to her emotions. When she was scared he got scared, when she was mad he hissed and growled, and when she was happy he purred in contentment. It turned out it was a lot easier to work on her temper and paranoia and even her self-hatred when the consequence of leaving it too long was Melog lashing out or being neglected. Still ballsy of Perfuma to have suggested instead of pushing one of her home-grown succulents for a test run. But highly effective.

Things hadn’t been perfect since then.

But somehow, they’d continued to get better, never quite hitting the invisible wall labeled *For People* Catra knew she couldn't move past. Instead her path slowly plodded up and down and further up to make progress. Always making progress in small ways, little victories Perfuma called them. Eating three meals a day instead of one, bathing more regularly, even just remembering to put clothes from the washer to the dryer. Each thing she did right, each victory she had just helped the world to feel steady under foot. Built confidence in her. Enough to even do something she'd wanted to do since she'd met the Grey's.

Her and Adora got married a year after her hospitalization, and with Entrapta overpaying them so severely, they’d even managed to buy a little house in a crummy but not totally bullshit area of

town. It was quiet and safe and theirs alone. Domestic and embarrassing when Glimmer and Bow cooed over them being "the cutest couple ever".

They were grown ups, adults doing taxes and living well. Hell, they even ended up getting their own vehicle!

When Mara's old Subaru finally gave out, they had held a little memorial for it waiting for the haul and pay tow truck.

"Pearl was a part of this family," Adora had sniffled. "And now she's gone to the big parking lot in the sky and- Pearl is the reason we aren't U-Haul lesbians Catra, stop laughing!"

But, really, Adora got the last laugh. Catra had to suffer when she rolled up to the office in a shitty looking beat up white truck that looked ready to give up the ghost like her mother in law's beloved Subey. She'd been all smug smiles, patting the truck's side, "Check it out, I'm calling him Swift Wind!"

Catra tried to walk home after that, but with Adora slowly following her with the hazards on and chatting away, Catra eventually gave in and got in the truck. Which was good, because Swifty was fucking clutch on the inside! New upholstery with a great stereo system, Adora was enamored with the fact that they had eight cup holders, and Catra was grateful that the AC worked and it had ass warmers. She even helped Adora put on the crummy rainbow decals in a sort of apology.

Now, Adora was enrolled full time at the nearby community college working towards becoming an EMT, and Entrapta offered to pay Catra almost double if she could work the night shift to help cover costs. So their life altered to fit two wildly different schedules.

It wasn't perfect.

But god if she wasn't happy.

“MMMmmmmm,” Adora whined pitifully as she tried to burrow between Catra’s shoulder blades, finally making up her damn mind on Catra's offer, “Okay! Okay! Fine, I’ll...I’ll do the stupid meditation!”

Catra chuckled and finally turned around, jumping up to sit on the counter so Adora could stand between her legs. “See, not so bad right!”

Adora rolled her eyes and simpered, “Teach me your ways oh wise one!”

“Don’t be a little bitch about it,” was her sage advice, “if I was able to make a habit you can too. And then you can meditate with me!”

Adora smirked. “Oh, are you asking me out?”

Catra laughed burying her face in Adora’s hair. Slowly breathing in the distinct smell of that animal and human shampoo she insisted on using because there was a horse on the label. She fumbled for a moment to find her coffee and took a sip from the comfort of her new perch, which sent Adora into a small giggle fit.

She winced looking at the clock, god she really had to get going soon and they hadn’t even talked about *it*. Entrapta wouldn’t care if she was late, but Catra did pride herself on doing a good job. ...okay, okay, so really Lonnie would never stop complaining if Catra, as the night shift supervisor, wasn’t there on time to supervise them. Whatever, same difference. Baby steps or whatever.

They still needed to talk about it.

“Hey,” she pushed Adora back just a little, awkwardly coughing and struggling to find a good segue before giving up on it entirely, “did you see the news?”

Adora half froze up before grimly nodding. “Yeah. Are you, I know this is awful timing, but are you okay?”

Mara had forwarded them both the online announcement. Beatrix Weaver Kur, dead at 64 after a long-fought battle with cancer. The obituary had listed her husband John Kur as her only surviving family member. No mention of her at all. Which was fair enough, she didn't even know the witch had gotten married and probably could have died happy not knowing. Still.

Still.

She shrugged, "Yes and no? More yes than no. I...she's really gone."

"Yeah."

Catra swallowed thickly, the mess of emotions inside her almost turning her stomach. "Guess we don't have to worry about her anymore."

"...do, do you want to go? To the funeral?"

She didn't have to think about that one, even if the email had kept her up most of the day she'd known the answer to that immediately. "No. It's...I see Perfuma tomorrow, I promise I'll bring it up. I j-just, it's that, It's that I, I- I mean, it's that I- fuck. Look, this- this won't be productive right now."

That had been one of Bow's suggestions, even if Scorpia had actually come up with the phrase. Something to say when something was important, but not critical. Something to say when her feelings turned from gentle bobbing swells to crashing rogue waves. Catra felt guilty for using it, but the relief was palpable. That woman was not really her mother, had hurt her horribly, and would never truly die. And Catra hated the way something in her still hurt at the idea that she'd never see her again. Never get a true goodbye or closure or explanation. She had to just keep living while Weaver was spared any consequences.

Her heart lurched painfully, but Adora's slow and steady breathing kept her grounded. They'd talk about *her* later if needed, but at

least it was out there now and not hovering in the back of her mind waiting for her to slip up.

"Okay," Adora ran her hands up and down her back before lifting her up and putting her on the floor like she weighed the same as a feather, "Gotta get showered for work, you stink."

Oh, it had been a completely innocent action, but god damn was it a great distraction. Catra stared at Adora's arms before looking back up into her face with a blush. "Uh, you've been working out."

Adora winked, clearly ready to derail any train of thought she might still be running, and flexed an arm. "Gotta be able to lift and carry people. Also, it'll be great for wall sex."

Catra's blush only got worse, because, yup, there it was. Whoo boy, yeah, okay, nice nice nice. But also, how dare she be a little shit when Catra couldn't stay and reclaim her throne. With no other options left and a literal ticking clock, Catra took the high road and only spluttered, "Oh my god, I'm going for a shower!"

Adora *still* clung to her shuffling along towards the bathroom to get every last second of contact. "Oh yeah? You want any company-"

"A **cold** shower so I can get to work!"

"You suuuuuure?" Adora asked with the most ridiculous voice, before literally gnawing at her shoulder for no apparent reason. "Nom, nom, nom!"

Catra shrieked, "EW! What the fuck Adora!? Gross!"

It was a small tussle to shove Adora's smirking face back before finally getting free and into the bathroom. Adora only stopped at the door for a moment to let her smirk soften into a sweet smile. "Hey. I love you.""

You can't change the past. Accept that it happened, move on, and spite her by living well. Yeah. This? This was truly living well.

Catra grinned back, “Love you too idiot.”

And then took great delight in slamming the door in her wife’s laughing face.

Chapter End Notes

> Not a perfect happily ever after, but a good and happy life regardless.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!